India's Civil Diplomat

Dr. Asif Iqbal did not wait for a government funds or support to build India's bilateral trade architecture — he built one himself, across 70 countries, one MoU, one trade desk, and one delegation at a time.



Dr. Asif Iqbal, President of the Indian Economic Trade Organisation (IETO)

Formal diplomacy moves at the speed of government. Trade opportunities move at the speed of commerce. The gap between those two speeds — where markets that should be open remain closed and Indian businesses with clear value propositions have no entry point — is the gap that Dr. Asif Iqbal has spent more than a decade systematically closing.

Dr. Iqbal operates in a rare category: a trained non-governmental individual who functions as mediator, advocate, and humanitarian agent — fostering international cooperation, peace, and social well-being through grassroots initiatives that outpace what formal diplomacy can deliver. The Indian Economic Trade Organization, which he co-founded in 2013, reflects that role precisely. It is not a chamber of commerce. It is a non-governmental trade facilitation institution with the reach of a ministry, the agility of a startup, and the institutional credibility of a body that has delivered results across 70 countries spanning Africa, the Middle East, Latin America, the Baltic, the Caribbean, and the Indo-Pacific.

The IETO's record reads less like an NGO's annual report and more like a Foreign Secretary's travel schedule. Dr. Iqbal led India's delegation to the St. Petersburg International Economic Forum. He received the First Lady of Zimbabwe at IETO alongside Ministry of External Affairs officials, then led a delegation that signed 19 MoUs covering smart mining, agriculture, tourism, healthcare, and film. He was hosted by the President of Armenia for the Summit of Minds. He organised the India Africa Economic Forum with ambassadors from 23 countries. He inaugurated India's Baltic, Cuba, Namibia, and Djibouti trade desks. He led India's first-ever business delegation to Papua New Guinea and Fiji, securing bilateral treaties. He received the Sarajevo Mayor's Medal and a Presidential Diploma from Bulgaria's Head of State. In Jamaica, a single IETO session drew 200 companies. He has stood alongside Sunil Mittal, Prakash Hinduja, Naushad Forbes, and Ram Madhav on delegations that shaped bilateral relationships across continents.

In 2022, Dr. Iqbal initiated the United Diplomatic Council in Brussels at the European Union Parliament — a platform designed to foster structured diplomatic engagement across nations and accelerate multilateral cooperation at the highest institutional level. His work also actively supports developing economies such as Kosovo in gaining global recognition, and creates sustained frameworks for interaction between industry, academia, and civil society. Critically, he helps shape policy by channelling direct inputs from industry into governmental decision-making — ensuring trade diplomacy stays grounded in commercial reality.

"Economic diplomacy is not just about trade," he has said. "It's about understanding cultures, building trust, and creating sustainable partnerships that benefit all parties involved."

That conviction extends to his 2025 book, ***Chronicles of Economic Diplomacy,*** launched by Chetan Bhagat — a documentation of twelve years of relationship-building that governments still struggle to replicate.